

Does the claim that God exists outside of time give us
reason to reject premise (2) of the foreknowledge
argument?

It does look like, if Aquinas' view is right, (2) is false. That
is good for the defender of free will.

We'll shortly consider some ways of responding to Edwards' argument. But first let's think about how Edwards' argument might be related to an argument for fatalism.

Suppose that someone did not believe in God — and hence rejected premise (2) of Edwards' argument — but did believe that there were truths about all of our future actions. Could they give an argument similar to Edwards' argument?

There are truths
about our future
actions.

We have no
choice about the
past.

If we have no choice
about A, and no
choice about the
connection between
A and B, then we
have no choice about
B.

In the past, God
had
foreknowledge of
our future
actions.

To get a grip on this, imagine that one learned of another universe, which had its own system of time and space. And suppose one was given all of the information about everything that ever happens in that universe, and the time at which it happens. So, in particular, you know everything about every free action in that universe. But it's not like you knew of every action **before** that action occurred — you don't exist in the time of that universe.

Let's look again at the premises which make
reference to time.

1. We have no choice about past facts.
2. In the past, God had foreknowledge of our future actions.
3. We have no choice about the fact that God knows that in the future I will perform a certain action. (1,2)

Let's return to the three assumptions which are common to both arguments. For now, I am going to set aside the last of these — we will come back to it next time.

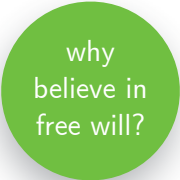
Let's start by asking whether we might deny the existence
of fate.



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

argument?

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2. In the past, God had foreknowledge of

performance: (1, 2)

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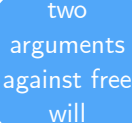
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freedom that comes from fate.

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predicto.

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

either.

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

things as fate, then there is no free will.

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

with reference to the being of truth about

our future actions.

God only shows up in premises (2) and

(5) Let's look at what happens if we



1. We have no direct facts.

God knows that in the future I will

that if it is true that I will perform

then we have the choice about q.

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

(3, 4, 5)

2*In the past, there were truths about

all of our activities.

5* We have not decided what the fact

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

perform a certain action (1,2)

3 We have not the fact that

0 We have achieved what we

acaioid.

some action, then I will prefer that



will perform various actions.

The fatalist argument

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